

EVALUATING THE POTENTIAL IMPACT OF WA DNR RECREATION CLOSURES

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PROJECT OVERVIEW

We are partnered with the Washington State Department of Natural Resources (DNR)

2025-2027 Operating Budget reduced: \$34 mil > \$25 mil

2026 Governors' budget: \$580,000 reduction

Backlog of work orders and limited staff

Loss of funding for Washington Conservation Corp partnership



RESTORE RECREATION FUNDING

REDUCTIONS IN RECREATION MAINTENANCE RESOURCES ARE CREATING AN UNSAFE ENVIRONMENT FOR HIKERS, BIKERS, CAMPERS, AND OTHER RECREATORS.



Recreation
investments support
1,300 miles of trails

More than 200
recreation sites

80 free
campgrounds

3.1 million acres

20 million visits
annually

237,000 jobs across
WA



CONSERVATION CORPS AND RECREATION LANDS

MAINTENANCE FUNDING have been crucial resources in helping the Washington Department of Natural Resources address resource dumping, public use, storm damage, and site safety across millions of acres of public lands.

RECREATION MAINTENANCE AND OPERATIONS

FUNDING was reduced by more than \$7 million in the 2025 legislative session; a more than **20% funding cut**. The Governor's proposed 2026 operating budget includes additional M&O reductions of \$750,000 per year. The 2025 funding cuts included legislative appropriation used to purchase time from the Washington Conservation Corps (WCC) and other corps programs. These young adult crews accounted for **nearly half of the total field capacity** available to DNR for trail and campground maintenance. DNR's very limited field staff have been left to try to keep up without the support of our corps partners.

AT CURRENT STAFFING LEVELS, DNR Recreation has 60 field staff across the state; meaning there is only **one staff person** per every **21.6 miles** of trail, **50,000 acres**, or **333,000 visitors** to DNR-managed lands. Further cuts will continue to be detrimental to the program and recreation access across Washington.

IMPACTS OF CONTINUED CUTS TO RECREATION MAINTENANCE FUNDING

- **DNR campgrounds and recreation sites are at risk of closure** due to eliminated funding for WA Conservation Corps Crews to support reopening.
- Reductions in access will impact user experiences.
- **Unsafe trail conditions**, including storm damage and illegal trash dumping, will not be addressed due to staff capacity.
- Trailheads and bathrooms will see more use and less ability to address daily use and cleaning.
- Increasing **backlog of maintenance**, which will become increasingly difficult and expensive to address with time.



Recreation maintenance funding allows for safe, accessible, and meaningful outdoor opportunities for recreators across Washington

QUESTIONS? PLEASE CONTACT:

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PROJECT OVERVIEW

19 sites (currently) considered for closure or service / maintenance reduction

DNR uncertain of impact to local communities and general public

Requested Tasks:

- Investigate socioeconomic effects
- Assess suitability of alternative DNR locations
- Assess suitability of alternatives operated by WA State Parks and USFS

POTENTIAL IMPACTS OF BUDGET REDUCTIONS

RECREATION SITE	COUNTY/LEGISLATIVE DISTRICT	LEVEL OF IMPACT
29 Pines Campground	Kittitas County, 13 th LD	Late opening, reduced services
Ahtanum Campground	Yakima County, 15 th LD	Late opening
Anderson Lake Campground (Tahoma State Forest)	Lewis County, 20 th and 2 nd LD	Full closure
Bear Creek Campground	Clallam County, 24 th LD	Full closure
Bradley Trails ORV Area	Wahkiakum County, 19 th LD	Full closure
Chopaka Lake and Cold Spring Campgrounds	Okanagan County, 7 th LD	Potential for full closure
Dougan Creek Campground	Skamania County, 17 th LD	Full closure
Dragoon Creek Campground	Spokane County, 6 th LD	Full closure
Green Mountain State Forest Trails	Kitsap County, 35 th and 36 th LD	Winter trail closures to dirt bike use
Harry Osborne State Forest	Skagit County, 39 th LD	Seasonal closures
Hoh-Oxbow Campground	Jefferson County, 24 th LD	Full closure
Island Camp Campground	Yakima County, accessed from Klickitat County, 14 th LD	Full closure
Lyre River Campground	Clallam County, 24 th LD	Full closure
North Mountain Trails and Skills Park	Snohomish County, 39 th LD	Service reductions
Reiter Foothills State Forest	Snohomish County, 12 th LD	Partial closures
Skookum Creek Campground	Pend Oreille County, 7 th LD	Full closure
Snoqualmie area sites	King County, 5 th LD	Seasonal bathroom closures
Tunerville Campground	Pacific County, 19 th LD	Full closure
Winston Creek Campground	Lewis County, 20 th LD	Full closure

TIMELINE

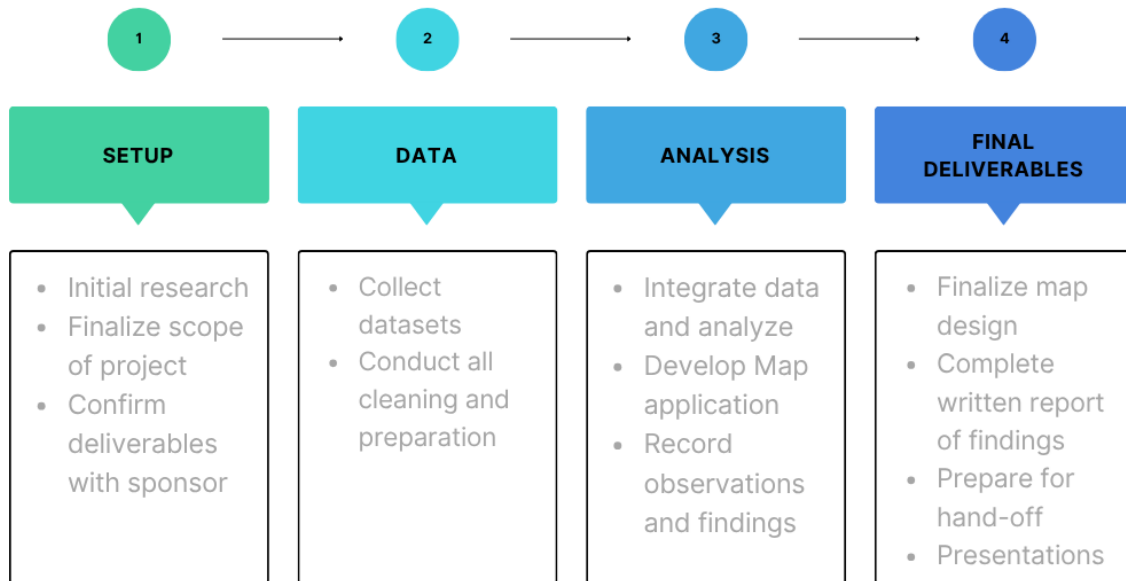
Milestone 1: Complete

Milestone 2: In Progress

Milestone 3: Upcoming

Milestone 4: Upcoming

Project Milestones



PROGRESS TO DATE

Activity Impact Analysis

INSIGHTS

- Closures not evenly distributed across recreation types
- Raw counts show high-use activities had largest losses
- Normalizing show smaller categories show higher proportional decreases

UPDATES

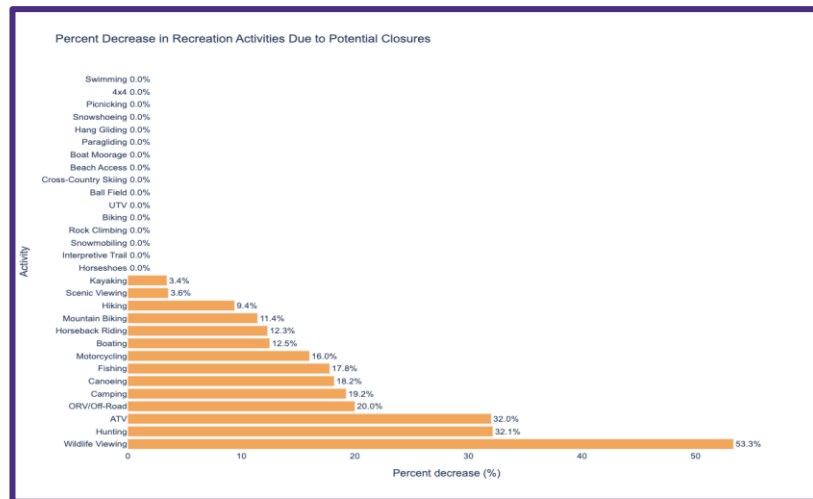
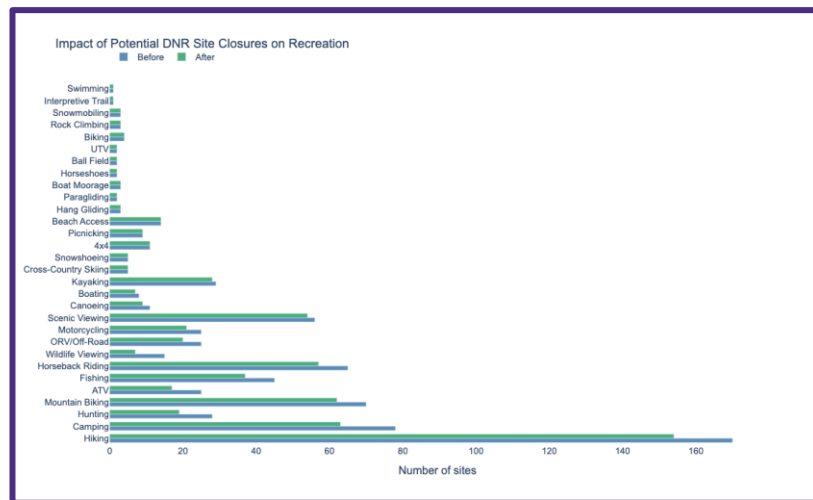
- Before vs after comparison of recreation sites by activity
- Raw counts -> normalized by calculating percent decrease
- Identified most affected activities
- Collected and cleaned ACS Census data (population, median income, vehicle availability)

CONCERNS & OBSTACLES

- No DNR demographic data
- Closure list not finalized
- Smaller activity categories may show higher variability in percent results

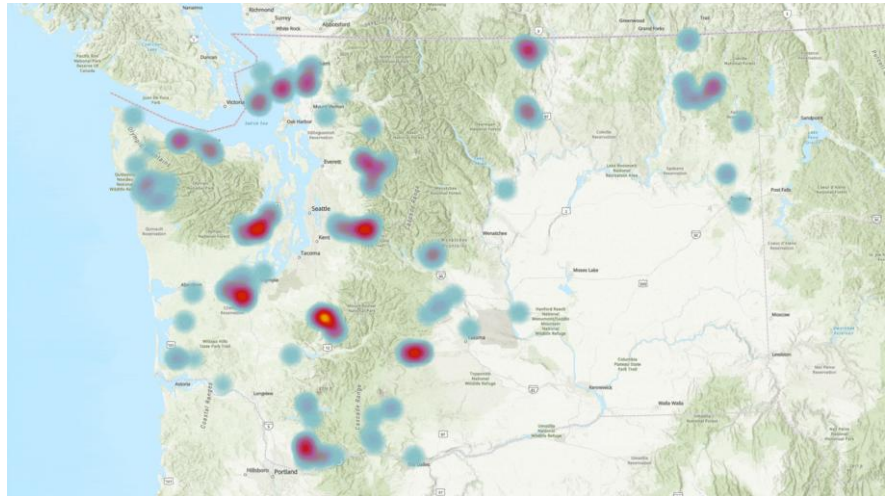
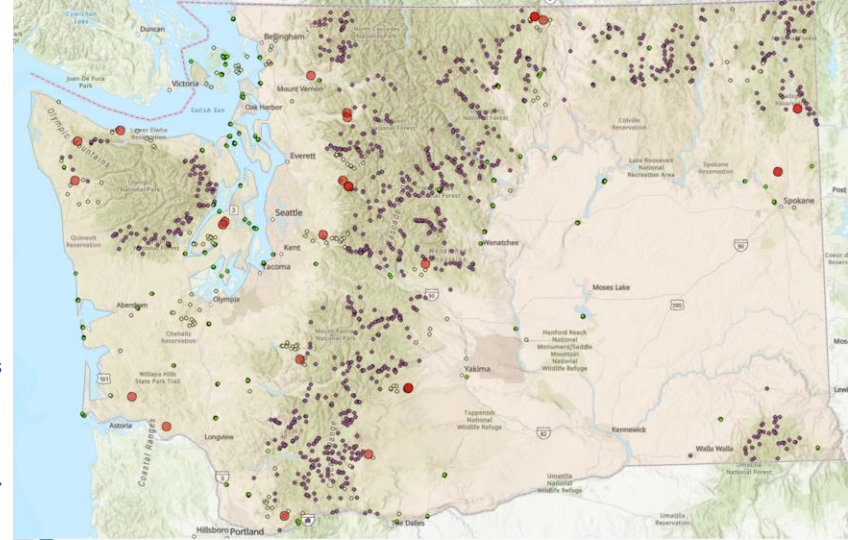
UNANTICIPATED DISCOVERIES

- Raw counts can be misleading without normalization
- Different methods lead to different interpretations
- Impacts vary by activity



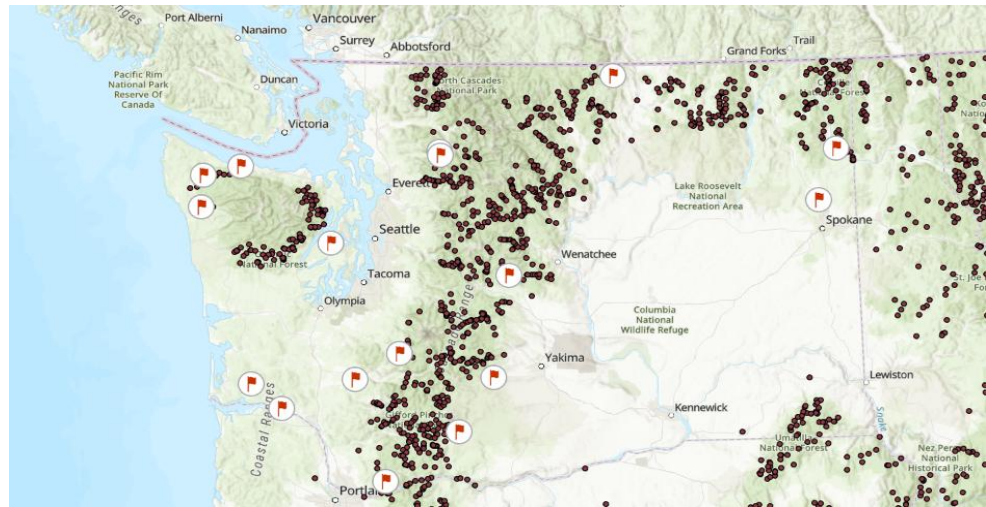
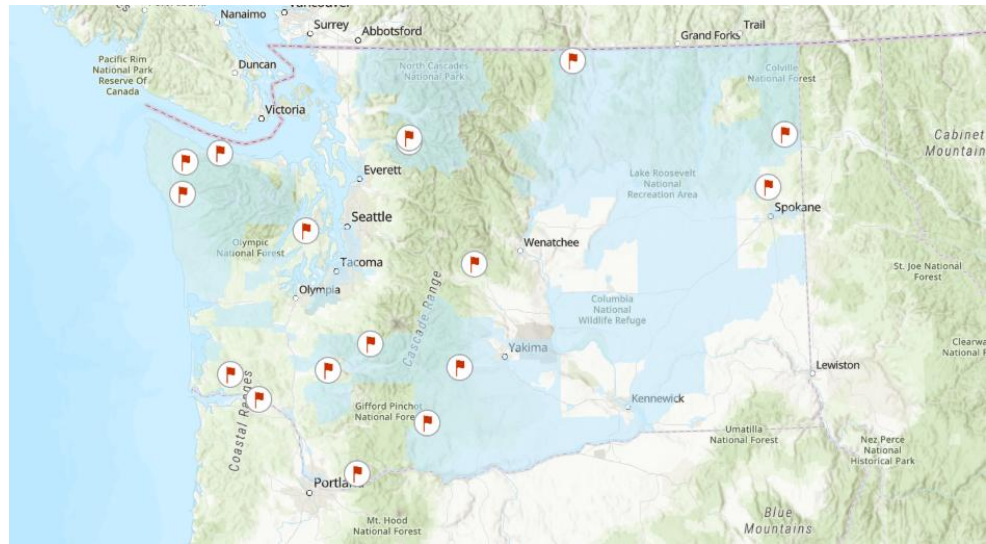
Area analysis

- **INSIGHTS**
 - Public transit access is best around Bellingham and Issaquah, poorer elsewhere
 - Some site closures are isolated, making it harder for communities to find alternatives
- **UPDATES**
 - Next steps are to break down service area by activity
 - Create Thiessen polygons showing which areas are closest to which park, before/after
- **CONCERNS & OBSTACLES**
 - Hardware limits to run driving service area analysis - may use Suzzallo computers
 - Too many activities, how to which ones to focus on and why they're important



Spatial Impact Analysis

- INSIGHTS
 - No definitive link found between the overburdened communities and the current listed potential closures
 - Many potential closures have extensive recreational spaces nearby with the exception of closures in the mouth of the columbia river
- UPDATES
 - Next steps include spatial analysis using geoprocessing tools to analyze which sites match up with the corresponding recreation activities available
- CONCERNS & OBSTACLES
 - Large datasets to filter out when matching up recreational areas
 - Lack of visitation data for each site facing closures



Equity / Environmental Justice

- **INSIGHTS**
 - Many (not all) proposed sites in census tracts with proportionally high levels of cardiovascular death
 - Near-all proposed sites in areas with proportionally high transportation expense burdens
 - EHD overall rank, no locations in areas of extreme health disparity, some in areas of moderate to high disparity
- **UPDATES**
 - Conduct analysis with rest of DNR / WA sites, see proportional change in available sites vs EHD
 - View same changes with WA State Parks and USFS locations
 - Continue comparisons of location changes to equity variables
- **CONCERNS & OBSTACLES**
 - Understanding labeling + classification logic can be challenging without clear documentation
- **UNANTICIPATED DISCOVERIES**
 - Some sites share a location but serve different activities, and not all the facilities are affected by the reductions
 - Need to distinguish between affected vs unaffected services

